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r/ucla • 10y ago

BatManatee MOD MIMG '13 and PhD '20



The Redditor's Guide to UCLA 2016

A few years ago, there was a [great post](#) on the sub with general info and suggestions about UCLA for new students. A couple users on the sub had the idea to remake it for the current year. So we are asking for everyone's input for anything you wished you knew as an incoming Freshman. I'll leave the post stickied for the next month or so. I'll also make another post for basic Q's and A's for new students.

Some questions to get everyone started are:

Where to eat?

How to get involved on campus?

Things to bring?

Academic advice?

Best places to study?

Fun things to do off campus?

Any Dorm/dining hall/freshman life advice? (I can't add much on those because that was quite a while ago for me)



69



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BatManatee OP • 10y ago

MIMG '13 and PhD '20

I'll start things off:

Some of my favorite restaurants in Westwood are

- Bella Pita--a great pita place owned by a UCLA prof
- Fat Sal's--massive sandwiches that are awful for you but great after a few drinks
- Ike's Sandwiches--Somewhat overpriced, but amazing sandwiches
- 800 degrees--One of the build your own pizza places (also Pieology and Open Oven are good too)



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amazing but I prefer Plan Check).

Go to class every time. No one is taking attendance anymore (usually) but your learning is your own responsibility now. And pay attention. You're paying to be there, use your time efficiently.

Study hard, you're probably used to being one of the smartest people in your high school. Just like everyone else at UCLA. You compensate for the harder competition by working harder. I did not take this seriously and when I first came to UCLA and I got my first C ever by bombing the first college final I ever took. It did kick my ass into shape, though.

Don't be afraid to talk to professors, they're just people, and most will be glad that you're interested in their class enough to approach them. NEVER ask for extra credit (it does not exist in 99% of college classes). And as a TA, use us for help! I want to help all my students but some aren't comfortable asking for it. Office hours are the best chance for me to interact with people personally.

We have a huge student body, as I'm sure you know. That is mostly a great thing, but it has a downside too. It means there is also something to do or someone to hang out with, but it means you can get lost in the herd if you don't put in the effort. During your first few weeks, go to EVERYTHING you're invited to, even if you're not interested. Most of the people you hang out with in the first few weeks aren't people you will stay close with for the rest of college. The only person I met that didn't enjoy UCLA couldn't figure this step out. She kept expecting fun to find her instead of making it happen.

There is no easier time to make friends in your entire life than the first few weeks of freshman year. EVERYONE is scared. EVERYONE is alone. Approach random people on your floor, in your classes, in clubs, and talk to them.

Buy a Den pass, it's worth it. Go to all sort of the sporting events you can. Football games eat up most of a day, but they were one of my favorite things. I still go to every home game.

During finals week, don't go to Powell to study. Every freshman thinks of it as THE UCLA library and it's the first place they go, so it is insanely crowded. There are like 10 other libraries on campus that you can go to and actually find somewhere to sit. My secret spot has always been the small library in the Geology building. A lot of people don't know it exists.

mortalenemas • 10y ago

800 also has a weekday instagram special for \$4 for dat student budget!



myeyes painted • 10y ago

Design | Media Arts '14

It's \$7 now :(

mortalenemas • 10y ago



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[\[deleted\]](#) • 10y ago

Yes to Bella Pita.



drwl • 10y ago

bella pita is owned by a professor? til



DutchFarmers • 10y ago • Edited 10y ago

Biochemistry '19

I'll just reiterate on some academic things because the social stuff has been covered very thoroughly on here and on [r/college](#).

- get started on work early and study often. Your mom isn't here to nag you about doing work and the quarter system moves quick so you'll find that assignments pile up. Also, study every day. People will boast about how they stayed up all night to study. Those people are idiots. Why stay up the night before when you can study a little bit every day and let your knowledge build up?
- make use of your planners from orientation. Once again, your mom isn't here. You are responsible for all deadlines and nobody will have any sympathy for you unless a doctor's note is involved.
- get involved in research early. This is huge for anyone who wants to go to grad or med school. The longer you wait to get into research the less competitive you become. Your competition will either have research experience already or be looking for positions right out of the gate. The cliched phrase "it takes experience to get experience" has some merit. Even if you're doing menial labor all you have to do is get your foot in the door for future positions.
- **put your studies first.** I'm not saying you can't have fun. Smart students will have fun *and* get good grades. If you put fun over studies you came to the wrong school. The competition here (especially for stem) will eat you alive. I've seen many intelligent people barely pass classes with Cs because they neglected their studies. You are here to learn.
- take 4 classes starting winter quarter. It's okay and even preferable to go light your first quarter but if you only take 3 classes every quarter you'll quickly fall behind in units which makes scheduling absolute hell. Many public schools have issues with guaranteeing seating to students in important major related classes and UCLA is no exception. You should have at least 45 units by the end of your first year. Anything below that and you'll start getting shafted for scheduling

Other advice:

- if you are unfortunate enough to live in a dorm without AC, buy a fan. A clip on fan will do. Dykstra was 90 degrees last year and my roommate literally passed out from the heat.
- if any adult tries to flag you down on Bruinwalk **do not stop and ignore them.** Especially if they are carrying a binder or say "can I ask you a question." These guys are notorious scammers who claim to be doing charity work but are really looking to steal money from freshmen and



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So can I ask you a question man is a confirmed scammer? Been wondering this for four years.



milkman182 • 10y ago

Environmental Science '17

I asked if they had a website so I could pay online to one guy and he told me it was his last day he could collect money... like wtf charity won't take my money if I want to give it later?



DutchFarmers • 10y ago

Biochemistry '19

Yes, it is confirmed a scam



caitberg • 10y ago

Keep in mind- UCLA is public property, and anyone like this guy can show up and collect signatures, proselytize, whatever. As long as they aren't hurting anyone, the school can't tell them to get lost.

Walooo • 10y ago

I'd say if you take summer classes, 4 classes isn't necessary. Also, really depends on your major, and if you can financially afford to spread out your classes or you absolutely need to graduate as early as possible and spend all summer working or other activities.

[deleted] • 10y ago

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DutchFarmers • 10y ago • Edited 10y ago

Biochemistry '19

No, it isn't too early. In fact, you should be looking for positions as soon as you get here.

Sometimes it's as easy as just asking. If one of your physics professors has some interesting research going on then go up to him and ask if you can help out. If you are taking a physics fiat lux your professor there may reach out to you and ask for help. You can send emails but you have to realize that many of these labs are either full or looking for people with knowledge/experience. SRP 99 can help but these positions are very competitive and most of the time they want people with prior lab experience. And lastly, network with your peers and make friends. This seems obvious but I managed to land a lab position this summer by



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I also suggest making a resume and attaching it to any email you send out.



sanitationengineer • 10y ago

- Some of the best bathrooms are in PAB, Humanities, Kaufman, Moore, Anderson, La Kretz and Terisaki. Upper floors of PAB are quieter for taking dumps. Some of the worst bathrooms are in Ackerman, Powell, and Boelter.
- If someone approaches you in a car asking for money for the hospital/medicine and offers to take you to the ATM, don't go. It's a scam. Generally older guys that are dressed in suits on Bruinwalk are also scammers.
- Treat other people well and leave a good impression of yourself. Many of the people you meet in the first week/month/year in classes/dorms/clubs will not become your close friend. You don't need to be best friends with your roommates, but you should respect them and make sure they respect you. You never know when an acquaintance you met a year ago becomes your study buddy in another class or scores you some old exams/labs because you were a cool person.
- 50 cent coffee at SEAS Cafe in Boelter from 5-6. 95 cents otherwise. It's not great coffee, but it's a third of the price of anywhere else and it's self serve so there's no wait. Cash only.
- Going out with your friends is great. But don't be afraid to go out alone and just enjoy yourself. Sometimes people's schedules/priorities will not align with your's, so don't let that stop you from going to the Getty or checking out a new club.
- Use a professional email. Safe format is firstname.lastname@ucla.edu or some variant. If you picked something stupid for your ucla version like geneblocksnipples@ucla.edu, make a gmail.



nolliethebum • 10y ago

Poli Sci '09

Basement floor of Humanities was always my clutch bathroom for dumps as a North Campus major.

Slpry_Pete • 10y ago

History/Poli Sci 1999

3rd floor (outside the ASUCLA offices) was my go to. Remember that 3rd floor Ackerman is actually the 5th or so floor

[deleted] • 10y ago

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nolliethebum • 10y ago

Poli Sci '09



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jonlle • 10y ago • Edited 10y ago

Chemistry/Materials Sci '17

For most of you, this is probably going to be the only short period of time in your life where you'll be surrounded by tons gifted people who come from a variety of different backgrounds. Make the most out of it.

Places that I frequently eat at:

- Tsujita - ramen
- Shin-Sen-Gumi
- Naab Cafe
- Saffron & Rose Ice Cream
- Diddy Riese

I'm more of a buy as you need kind of guy. I find that if I try to over-prepare and buy beyond the basic essentials, I end up buying some unnecessary stuff. Take advantage of that Amazon Prime Student perk. **Just realized that buying a second monitor was one of my favorite purchases for productivity reasons.

I don't really have any academic advice other than the obvious fact that you need to study. Here at UCLA, you'll really find out what your strengths are. At times I'm getting one of highest scores in the class, and other times I'm near the bottom of the curve where a C is at. Realizing this made me way more comfortable with my own academic performance and helped me narrow down the type of careers I want to pursue in the future.

When it's 10th/Finals week and it gets really packed, I like to study in the hallways of Young Hall. There are tables in the hallways (with outlets) where the labs are on 3rd floor and above. Reading in between hallways feels sorta cool too as long as you're not in a high-traffic area/obstructing space.

LACMA/The Grove/Santa Monica are all fun places to go on the weekend. For all of these places, none of my Uber rides have ever costed over \$8.

Side note: Don't be intimidated by like the seeming 70% people you meet in your first year who say they're planning on doing an MD+PhD while becoming an astronaut on the side. By my senior year, I've noticed that everyone's plans have steered in a different direction to some extent. I've always felt that at UCLA, there's a lot of "ambition-shaming" but you get over it pretty quickly and stick with what you actually want to do.



yubugger • 10y ago



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[\[deleted\]](#) · 10y ago

Join a student group ASAP

Uber with your date to Saffron & Rose Ice Cream on Westwood, get orange blossom flavor

Make friends with your RAs and they might just overlook that wine bottle on your desk

Biking is an effective way to get around campus once you figure out the best routes to your classes--there's a great bike shop on campus

Every once in awhile you'll see two skateboarders crash into each other on Bruinwalk--a sight to behold

If you need the support, utilize CAPS therapists while you can (I know they recently cut some funding, but still a good resource)

Ashe Medical Center is helpful to an extent, but they do not offer first aid and sometimes mis-prescribe things, be wary

Dining halls fill up on the hour because most classes get out at ten til

Feast at Rieber is underrated

You've never before seen foot traffic like Bruin Walk's

UCLA CAP (not therapy) often offers free tickets to students for incredible concerts at Royce, keep an eye on the website

[greasetree](#) · 10y ago

- aside from the dining halls (all are amazing), my go-to in westwood is Bibigo (make your own bibimbap bowls, slight student discount). 800 degrees pizza of the day on instagram is a good choice also
- get involved by joining clubs or organizations. anything you may be interested in, even if it's something you're not currently familiar with or good at. do this early, because you'll get into a groove later on and pick your favorite things to occupy your time. be friendly and get off your computer. you're only at ucla for 3/4 of the year, for 4-5 years of your life. take advantage of the student life at UCLA before it's too late.
- find academic advice from older students if possible. take advantage of bruinwalk and myedu reviews and class curves. don't procrastinate.
- my favorite places to study were libraries or places in the early morning. it wouldn't be crowded, and if you study in the morning you'll feel productive for the rest of the day. take some time eventually to go exploring on campus and find your own secret spot. I could tell you mine, but



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taken weekend trips to San Diego, had photoshoots at the Getty, karaoke-ing or food on Sawtelle, etc etc. especially if you're not from LA, use free weekends to go explore!

- just general advice: take care of yourself. make sure you take time for your own well-being and putting your health and mental health first, especially if you're active in a lot of clubs and organizations on top of your academics. if you need it, there are always counselors at CAPS. people don't talk about how stressful college can be, and trust me, everyone is stressed at times. it will take time to learn about how you handle stress, but you'll be okay, and it's part of the college experience.
- you don't need to have your life figured out, but you still need to try to have at least some type of plan. I've seen people who graduate having no idea what they want to do, and people who have too many breakdowns trying to follow their life plan. I fell somewhere in the middle (maybe a little closer to the latter) and I'm pretty happy with how I turned out. ambition will do wonders for you, but don't break your back trying to follow your dreams.

Slpry_Pete · 10y ago

History/Pol Sci 1999

I've posted this before, but my advice is to bring less than what you think you need for a few reasons.

1. You are going to live in LA, you can go and buy anything you really need in a pinch, if you really need it. You'd be surprised how much you can do without and still survive/thrive. You will be (or at least should be) so busy you won't miss much of your stuff.
2. if you are going to UCLA you are more than likely a California resident. Anything you may have forgotten is no more than a day drive away. Parents weekend comes about 4 weeks into the first quarter. If there is something you absolutely need someone can bring it to you. After that Thanksgiving is just a few more weeks away, you are probably going home for Thanksgiving. Also your new friends (or just people you know from high school) will probably be making a trip back home for some birthday/wedding/bar mitzvah, you can stow away a ride or arrange a pickup for your stuff. Again if it is that important you will find a way to get it. Also USPS, UPS, FedEx, Amazon.....
3. You are going to be living in West LA. As far as clothes go you need very little. Tshirt and shorts work for about 90% of the time. It gets cool in the evening and early morning sometimes, bring a pair of jeans and sweatshirt. The little bit of rain doesn't come until after Christmas break so you don't really need to worry about that. Also Ackerman (the student store) has a big sale on Halloween where you can get an extra sweatshirt or sweatpants. You'd be surprised how many things they sell in there. Bring a nice outfit for going out socially and a professional outfit for interviews, but these can be worn more than once. You don't need a full wardrobe to choose from.
4. If you live in a dorm (or even most apartments) space is at a premium. Better to have less stuff from home and more room for the stuff you really need. Also it is better to buy things that fit into the small spaces that you have. Do you know exactly how much room is between the end of your bed and closet? How about under your desk? How much room is there on your desk for a printer or monitor or stapler or lamp? Better to know that and buy something that fits (trashcan, laundry hamper) at Target (on Amazon) after you see the space. Again you will probably have some time



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suckstobejake • 10y ago

Now an alum. Some things I can think of at the top of my head:

Join a student group! This is a huge school. I think I underestimated the value of joining groups (and sticking with them) until my first year was over. **I really recommend joining Unicamp.** They do interviews at the end of Winter quarter and do their training meetings once a week during Spring quarter. Seriously, so many people do Unicamp. It really got me close with a large group of people and helped me really expand my network.

Food:

- Best lunch on-campus: the Italian restaurant connected to Anderson Business school. I liked it for lunch.
- Best breakfast: good burrito bowls in the food court next to Northern Lights are only ~\$2. I forgot the name of the place.
- Panda Express Kitchen in Westwood opened up recently, past old Yamato and towards Wilshire. They have orange chicken burritos.
- Sushi - Ami Sushi's happy hour was always my favorite. I think it's too pricey outside of the happy hour. Also, their old manager was so cute. I'm sad he left.

Dorms:

- Be nice to your RA and go to their programs. Honestly, you just going to them (even for the beginning) will probably make them like you.
- Befriend your RDs (resident director). They're the ones you'll have to answer if your RA ever writes you up. I used to work for ResLife and being at least familiar with my RD got me a job, got me a spot in the dorms my third year, and got certain incidences overlooked.

Bathrooms:

- Best bathrooms are in Kaufman because they're clean and accessible.
- If you're going to consider using the restrooms in Ackerman, just don't. And go to the SAC across Bruinwalk. Ackerman is pretty gross.

Academics:

- I'd really recommend taking a class in the VAPAE (Visual and Performing Arts Education) department. Not many people know about it, though the intro class really changed the trajectory of my college experience. It's a small class and I really got to know everyone in it. It's still one of my favorite courses I've ever taken just because of how unconventional it was (unless you're a WAC major, then it's pretty standard).
- If there's ever a class you need to write a paper for, talk to the professor or the TA that will grade your paper. By you talking to them beforehand, they will be familiar with what you're trying to



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probably in an easy class (make sure to still do the work though).

I'll add more later if I can think of anything else!

[deleted] • 10y ago

Should I wait for the UniCamp application window to uh open? I'd really be interested in doing this



suckstobejake • 10y ago

Yes! They usually open around at the beginning of winter quarter so keep an eye out on Facebook. If you have any questions, please don't hesitate to ask me in a pm.

[deleted] • 10y ago

Thanks!



Jophyy • 10y ago

B Plate is the shit

[deleted] • 10y ago

Older alum here:

1. Study hard, but if you don't want to go to grad school don't sweat a B or twenty. Your GPA is a blip in your life. Nobody has asked mine since I applied for grad school. I worked super hard on it, too. Go figure.
2. Your major doesn't determine your career. I work in STEM, but my degree is in poli sci and Japanese. But if you're a north campus major, seriously consider at least learning some math, stats, or Econ. It will help you a great deal even in applying your major studies.
3. In professional learning: do internships! Don't spend your summers at home with your folks. Do an internship. Apply early and often and get work experience. It will help you a great deal in the long run, if only in learning how to apply for jobs. But get paid.
4. If you can, do EAP. You will rarely get the chance to live abroad so easily. Take it.
5. Do research. You attend a world-class research university. Get involved in some of it. Even us lame north campus dweebs can do it!

Most of all: have fun!



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Where to eat in WW: Gushi (fast food kbbq), Chipotle, Innout, Flame Broiler (like a healthy Yoshinoya)

Dorm food: You have an entire year, so try everything. Check the menu. I don't know if they still do it, but lamb chops at Bplate are can't miss.

How to get involved: Go to the enormous activities fair, and take every flier you see on Bruin Walk. Be open minded. You might be surprised to find which activities stick and which ones don't. Don't stay with something if you don't like the people. There's over 1000 clubs/orgs out there. There's so much to gain outside of the classroom.

Academic advice: Seek help. Go to tutoring/office hours. There's TA's office hours, another TA's office hours, or your professor's office hours. Ask questions on the CCLE discussion forum. Find someone/anyone who's in your class, or taken the class before. You might be used to figuring out and doing everything yourself, but it will screw you over at least a few times.

[deleted] • 10y ago • Edited 10y ago

- The only places I really love near campus would have to be Tacos Tu Madre and Ike's Place. If you want to make it out to Santa Monica/Topanga I'd suggest trying Cha Cha Chicken, Sugarfish, and Inn of the Seventh Ray. These places are great for dates.
- Working on campus and/or joining clubs is a great way to get involved.
- The quarters go by quickly so make sure you keep up on your work/reading or you will regret it when midterms and finals approach. I tended to get more work done at the library compared to anywhere else so I'd suggest figuring out where you do your best work. Go to your professors or TA's office hours. If they know your name this can help with grades and references. Oh and there's a testbank on campus (at the SAC) that has helped me out with quite a few classes. Keep tests you get back so you can keep using the bank every quarter (you don't need to provide a test your first quarter but you will need to for every other quarter).
- Things you should definitely do your first year would have to be going to the football games, basketball games, The Getty Center, and Hammer Museum. If you aren't from LA get out and explore. There's a lot of awesome stuff to do and see outside of Westwood.
- Enjoy UCLA! Work hard but make sure to have fun. Go Bruins!



size6 • 10y ago

So apparently Starbucks is no longer open 24/7, which means there aren't any 24/7 studying spaces in Westwood anymore outside of Night Powell, which doesn't apply on Fridays, and dorm common areas.



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[deleted] • 10y ago

Well im not new but is it fine to ask profs that don't know you that well for rec letters if it comes down to that? Better than not having them at all right for grad school?

BatManatee OP • 10y ago

MIMG '13 and PhD '20

You can definitely ask, worst they can say is no. But the "friendly" professors that teach upper division classes get flooded with requests each year. Mine got 20 requests from a class of about 100 students.

I'd recommend at least going to office hours a few times so they start to know you a little bit.

[deleted] • 10y ago

Ok there were definitely professors in lower division classes that knew me back then but its been a long time now and I doubt they remember after like 2-3 years.